more concerned about the welfare of its diaspora.

Q. 20 Discuss the challenges related to providing universal healthcare in India.

Ans. Health indicators of India have been always low due to many resons and they still remain a matter of great concern for the GoI and UN bodies. Despite higher economic growth, India fares poorly when compared to countries like China and Sri Lanka in term of parameters like per capita expenditure on health, number of physician/hospital beds and IMR. In addition, within the country, the improvement has been quite uneven across regions/states, gender, rural/urban areas, etc. The health system in India is a mix of the public and private sectors, with the NGO sector playing a small role. In providing universal healthcare, the country faces the following challenges:

Physical challenges are related to having adequate number of trained personnel, hospitals and other infrastructure. The centre and state need active participation from the private sector and the NGOs.

Economic challenges are related to the mobilisation of funds to meet the physical challenges at one hand, while on the other, delivering the required medical services to the needy people.

Universal health insurance is under consideration with government supported premium payment.

Government plans to promote the private sector and NGOs in its preperation for putting the right kind of physical set up while the delivery is to be taken care via the UID based insurance smart cards. Planning Commission has targeted to increase health expenditure to 2-3 per cent of GDP in the 12th Plan (from 1 per cent of GDP of the 11th Plan). However, sceptics doubt the efficacy of the smart card-based healthcare delivery due to information divide in the country.

Q. 21 Examine India's food security in light of the record foodgrain production is 2010-11.